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List of Variables

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A report on mathematical modelling will necessarily contain mathematics. It will include formulas, variables and perhaps make use of constants. Think of the gravitational constant G for example. Whenever you start using a new symbol in your text, you should explain its meaning.

However, a reader may eventually forget the meaning or value of one or more of your symbols. To help this reader, it is customary to provide a list of variables. All variables, functions, constants and symbols used in your report should be listed here, along with their definitions or explanations, and, when applicable, their units.

Some examples of listed variables and constants:

G : Gravitational constant $6.674 \times 10^{-11} \text{ m}^3\text{kg}^{-1}\text{s}^{-2}$

t : Time days

$P(t)$: Number of rainbowfish in the aquarium at time t rainbowfish

If your report uses only a truly minimal number of constants and variables, it might be better not to include a List of Variables. In most cases, however, the List of Variables will provide a very useful resource for your reader.

Exercise A

1/1 point (graded)

List of Variables

$P(t)$: The number of rainbowfish at time t

$G(t)$: The number of gouramis at time t

a : The fraction of rainbowfish eaten by each gourami per day

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What improvements should be made to the List of Variables above?

- ☒ The time variable t and its unit should be added.
- ☐ $P(t)$ and $G(t)$ should be described more explicitly, including their units.
- ☒ The values of the constants a and b should be added (if they are constants).
- ☒ The variable b should be described more explicitly.



Answer

Correct:

Indeed, time is clearly a variable here and should therefore be mentioned in the List of Variables.

If a and b are variables, their values need not be listed. But when they are constants used in the report, the reader should be able to find their values here.

The current description for b is vague, and its unit cannot be derived from this explanation.

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You have used 4 of 10 attempts

✓ Correct (1/1 point)

We're moving towards the end of the report: the next page will take a look at the formatting of the bibliography.

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